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BELATED:
Workers
putting
checks at
Nepal's
Kusaha em-
bankment

with the airdropping of food packets discontinued, army boats are being used for some 70,000 odd people who have stayed put in the villages.

The worst of times seems to have brought the worst in few men. A Bihar police sub-inspector K.K. Choudhary was arrested for allegedly molesting a flood victim. Earlier, seven people were arrested on the charge of molesting women from Laxmipur village under Jankinagar police station of Purnia. Over hundred complaints of thefts in houses abandoned by their owners due to the floods have been reported. There have been reports of unscrupulous private boatmen molesting women, who had taken shelter in their boats. But such incidents seem to have come down after the army took over the evacuation process.

Visibly alarmed, Bihar authorities have initiated steps to beef up security in the flood-affected districts. The chief minister has ordered deployment of police personnel at all relief camps. Additional security forces have been rushed to the affected districts and more than 4,000 army personnel and National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) have been deployed there.

However, many victims who escaped the flood fury have suffered official apathy. So far, the state Government has shifted three district magistrates (DM), one superintendent of police (SP) and one civil surgeon for their "inept" handling of the situation

arising out of the calamity. Rajesh Kumar, who was replaced by Atish Chandra as Madhepura DM recently, was the third IAS officer to be shifted. Earlier, DMS of Saharsa and Supaul and the SP of Supaul were transferred for poor distribution of relief materials and special DMS were sent from the state headquarters to fill in for them.

Meanwhile, the political fraternity unanimously admits that this was an avoidable disaster. RJD President and Railways Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav

has admitted that the floods will be an issue during the elections, while Union Minister Ram Vilas Paswan has demanded an inquiry into Kosi embankment breach, alleging that the relief measures initiated by the state Government were too little and too late. While the state Cabinet has decided to set up a judicial commission headed by a retired high court judge to inquire into the causes of the August 18 breach in the Kosi afflux bund that led to the devastating flood and to fix responsibility, the strident political voices and the acrimonious blame game between the Centre and Bihar over who turned a deaf eye to flood is yet to subside. The politicians know that their posturing at this moment may give them an edge in at least seven Lok Sabha seats (Saharsa, Madhepura, Araria, Kishanganj, Purnia and Katihar), which are inhabited by many flood-affected people.

The continued presence of Yadav, Paswan and Kumar in the flood-ravaged districts has been conspicuous. However, the state's Water Resources Minister Bijendra Prasad Yadav, who is being blamed for his failure to repair the embankment, is believed to be the weakest link in Kumar's camp.

The victims, however, need more. There are bigger questions of how and when will the mighty river be embanked once again. Till this is done, the victims will be destined to live in the belly of the river.

UNENDING TRAGEDY

■ **Flooding and stagnant water are ideal breeding conditions for mosquito vector. Overcrowding facilitates mosquito bites and transmission. As a result, outbreak of malaria and dengue is feared.**

■ **Decaying bodies of cattle can be potent source of harmful micro-organism. Rotten food and grains from deserted homes and shops breed infection.**

■ **Wells and drinking water sources are contaminated with polluted drinking water.**

■ **Overcrowding and inadequate shelters lead to respiratory infections, and pose a serious threat to children.**